

The Paramythia Stack

What to buy, what to postpone, and what not to buy at all — sequenced against the gates so the spending only ever follows evidence.

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The rule

Every subscription is bought at the gate that needs it, monthly, never annually. You asked to know whether this works before committing real money — a tool stack bought up front quietly converts that question into a sunk cost you will then feel obliged to justify.

The good news: **Gate 0 costs nothing.** You already own everything it needs. The first real money is roughly **\$150**, and it arrives only after you have heard your own script read aloud in Greek and decided it is worth continuing.

The whole first year, at a sustained four videos a month, lands near **\$1,300–1,700** — and every part of it is cancellable monthly.

PHASE ONE

Buy now: nothing

GATE 0 · THIS WEEK	\$0
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Gate 0 is one bilingual script and a narration test. Everything it requires, you have.

TOOL	WHY	COST
Claude	Orchestration, scripts, the Greek editor pass. Your existing plan is fine until you hit limits.	have it
GitHub	Private repos are free. Already set up.	\$0
Figma	You already hold a Pro seat on your own team. Identity file is built.	have it
ElevenLabs	Free tier covers a two-language narration test comfortably. No commercial licence, but Gate 0 publishes nothing.	\$0
Verify current pricing before any purchase — these move.		

THE POINT

You can answer the single most disqualifying question in this project — does the Greek sound right to a native ear — for nothing, this week. No other spend makes sense before that answer exists.

PHASE TWO

Buy at Gate 1: the pilots

WEEKS 2–6

~\$150 once + \$37/mo

Only once Gate 0 passes. This is the money that buys you three finished videos and a real answer on cost per episode.

TOOL	WHY	COST
fal.ai credits	Image and video generation for all three pilots, including the deliberately expensive Pilot B comparison	~\$150 once
ElevenLabs Creator	Upgrade needed for the commercial licence the moment you publish anything	\$22/mo
Music library	Six cleared cues. Epidemic Sound or Artlist. Not AI-generated music — see below.	~\$15/mo
Google Cloud	YouTube Data API project for programmatic upload. Free tier is ample.	\$0
Gate 1 total	Three pilots, fully finished	~\$225
fal.ai is credits, not a subscription — buy \$150 and it lasts until spent. Credits expire after 365 days.		

PHASE THREE

Buy at Gate 2: sustaining

MONTHS 2–4

~\$95–135/mo

Ten to twelve videos on a steady cadence. The only change from Gate 1 is topping up fal.ai as you actually consume it, at roughly \$15–25 per finished video in storybook-motion style.

One possible addition: if you find yourself blocked by Claude usage limits while running the pipeline, that is the moment to move up a plan — not before. Upgrading in anticipation of a bottleneck you have not hit is exactly the pattern this document exists to prevent.

When your wife joins

Worth being precise here, because the instinct is to buy her a seat on everything. **She needs almost none of the production stack.** Sales and marketing sits downstream of the pipeline, not inside it.

NEED	TOOL	COST
Shared credentials	1Password or similar. The first genuine requirement of a second person.	~\$5/mo
Work tracking	GitHub Projects — free, already in the repo, and issues link to the commits that resolve them	\$0
Analytics	YouTube Studio. Genuinely good, and free.	\$0
Figma	Viewer seats are free. She can comment on thumbnails without a paid seat.	\$0
Social scheduling	Only once there is a posting cadence worth automating. Not before.	defer
Distribution and production barely overlap. Buy seats for what someone actually touches.		

ON COHERENCE

What makes this joinable is not tooling — it is that the repo already holds the style bible, the prompt kit, the character spec and the gates. Someone can read those and know what the thing is, what it must never do, and what would make you stop. That is worth more than any project-management subscription, and you already have it.

Do not buy

- NO

JIRA. You named it, so let me argue properly. JIRA is built for engineering teams coordinating sprints across dependencies. Your unit of work is an episode moving through a fixed eight-beat pipeline — already described in the style bible, already tracked by files on disk. The cost is not the licence, it is the ceremony: boards, workflows and ticket hygiene that consume hours you do not have at a headcount of one. GitHub Issues plus Projects is free, lives beside the code, and will hold until you are three or more people. Your familiarity with Atlassian from work is real, but familiarity with a tool is not the same as it being right at this scale.
- NO

Suno or any AI music generator. Two independent reasons. The free tier grants no commercial rights at all, and fully AI-generated audio is not eligible for Content ID, so you could never protect a cue you liked. Layered on top is unresolved label litigation. A licensed library costs \$15/month and removes the entire category of risk.

NO

Adobe Creative Cloud, Canva Pro, or a video editor subscription. Assembly is ffmpeg driven by Claude Code, and everything composable is a Figma component. Buy an editor only if you find yourself fighting ffmpeg for hours — and note that would itself be a finding worth acting on.

LATER

A domain and channel name. The name is deliberately deferred until after Gate 1. Buying a domain now anchors you to a name chosen before you had seen any finished video.

LATER

A company, business bank account or accountant. Premature until there is revenue or a second person taking equity. Revisit at Gate 3.

LATER

Annual billing on anything. The discount is real and it is a trap here. Monthly billing is what keeps the kill criteria honest.

PART SIX

Things you did not ask about, and need

1. A dedicated Google account — do this first

Not your work account, and not your main personal one. The channel, the Google Cloud project, the OAuth credentials and the API quota all hang off a single Google identity, and disentangling that later is genuinely painful. Create it before the channel exists. When your wife joins, YouTube Brand Account permissions let you grant her access without ever sharing a password.

DO NOT SKIP

A channel created under your CEPR work account is a channel your employer has a plausible claim to look at, and one you could lose access to if you changed jobs. Ten free minutes now.

2. Somewhere for the generated assets to live

Frames, clips and renders are deliberately excluded from git — they are large and reproducible. But "reproducible" means paying fal.ai again, so treat them as worth keeping. A single external SSD covers the pilot phase for a one-off cost; cloud object storage runs a few dollars a month per terabyte if you would rather not think about it. Either is fine. Having neither is how you lose Pilot A.

3. A channel email address

Comes free with the dedicated Google account, and is what goes in the channel's About page for licensing and brand enquiries. Which, per the brief, is where the actual money is more likely to come from than advertising.

What the year costs

SCENARIO	WHAT HAPPENS	TOTAL
Stops at Gate 0	The Greek does not land, or the script bores you. You learn this in week one.	\$0
Stops at Gate 1	Three finished pilots exist. You know your true cost and hours per video.	~\$225
Stops at Gate 2	Twelve videos published, no traction. Roughly four months in.	~\$600
Runs the full year	~48 videos, a real catalogue, a genuine answer	~\$1,300–1,700
Assumes storybook-motion style at four videos a month. Full AI animation roughly triples the generation line.		

The shape that matters: **the cheapest outcomes are the ones where you stop early**, and the gates are designed to make stopping early easy and unembarrassing. You asked whether this works. That is a question with a \$225 answer, not a \$4,500 one.

Four things, none of which cost money

1. **Create the dedicated Google account.** Ten minutes, and everything else hangs off it.
2. **Pick three fables and one Greek folk tale.** Your enjoyment is a real input; you will read these a hundred times.
3. **Run Gate 0.** I write the bilingual retelling, we generate narration in both languages, you listen.
4. **Decide the host's name.** The character spec is locked and waiting on it.

Then, and only then, spend the \$150.